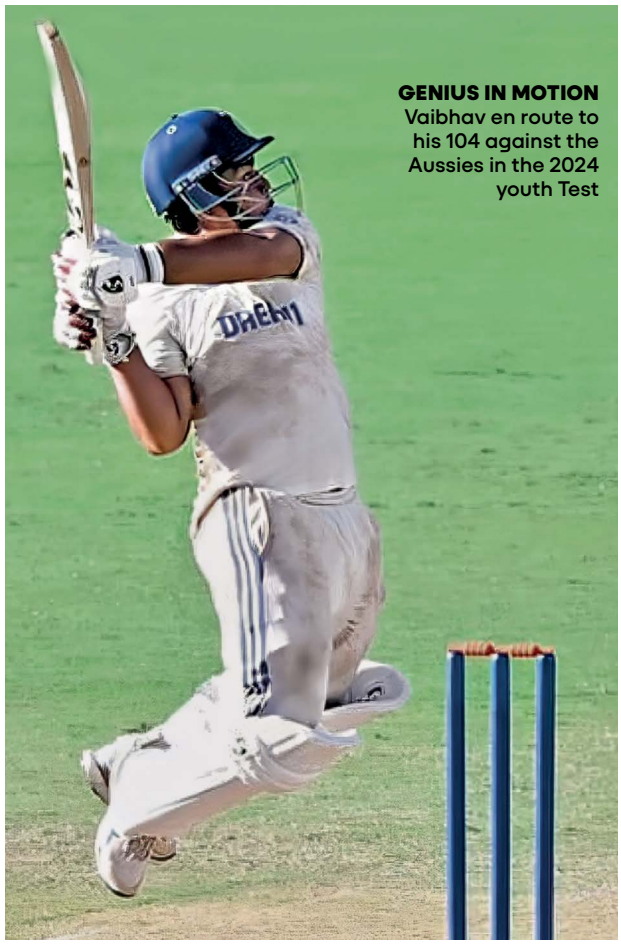


GENIUS IN MOTION Vaibhav en route to his 104 against the Aussies in the 2024 youth Test

arm remains straight, creating leverage. There is also a slight back-and-across trigger movement before he commits to the stroke. But the true engine of his batting lies in the hands: impossibly quick, and capable of converting a reasonable-length delivery into a boundary before the bowler has quite completed his follow-through. Cricket legend Sachin Tendulkar says, "To be able to play in all directions of the ground, you need good wrist work. Vaibhav is not slogging the ball. He is just picking the line and length earlier than the rest of the guys and clearing the rope comfortably."

A MOTHER'S IMPACT

Vaibhav comes from a close-knit family with two brothers. Mother Aarti Singh, a homemaker, embodies the quiet, less visible part of the sacrifice upon which Indian sporting dreams are often built. During the training years, she would prepare 10 lunch boxes before dawn—one for Vaibhav, the others for the net bowlers who travelled with him. This year, when Vaibhav formed the letter 'A' with his hands during the blistering 93 against LSG on May 19, it was a tribute to the woman whose sacrifices had shaped his journey long before the stadium lights shone bright on him.

That boy is also learning to handle the limelight and expectations around him. "When people talk about me, I try not to pay too much attention to it. I try not to overthink these things," Vaibhav said after being named Player of the Match on May 19. "In my mind, this is only the beginning. If my career is long, people will naturally say many things. My focus must remain on the game...on completing my journey well."

SPORTS

CRICKET

THE NEXT BIG PITCH

Asked about any obvious chinks in Vaibhav's batting, Indian batting legend Sunil Gavaskar was cautious in his remarks. "At the moment, he is playing white-ball cricket and dominating it," he said. "Nobody seems to have found any weaknesses in his game so far."

True, having swept the major batting honours in IPL 2026, Vaibhav has rendered the 'second-season syndrome' irrelevant. But the goalpost has shifted. The question now is whether he can conquer conditions far removed from the batting havens of the IPL. Can he thrive on the pace and bounce of Australia, the seam-friendly tracks of England? "I don't foresee any problems for him in limited-overs cricket because pitches across the globe—whether in England, Australia or South Africa—are generally batting-friendly in white-ball matches, so the question of adjustment doesn't arise," argues former India batter Mohammad Kaif.

Yet the conversation around Vaibhav has never been confined to white-ball cricket. Comparisons with a teenage Sachin Tendulkar—who announced himself with centuries on debut in the Ranji and Irani trophies before making an extraordinary entry into Test cricket—have inevitably fuelled the belief that red-ball success will be the ultimate measure of his greatness.

"Why the hurry to push him into Test cricket? He's doing really well in the shorter form. Let him continue for a while...there is enough time for him to graduate to red-ball cricket"
—Mohammad Kaif

Kaif, though, is unconvinced. "Why is there such a hurry to push him into Test cricket?" he asks. "What he is doing in white-ball cricket is incredible. Why not let him continue in the shorter form of the game for a couple more years? Isn't that a gift in itself? There's enough time for him to graduate to red-ball cricket."

And while a first-class average of 17 in eight Ranji Trophy matches may not make for great reading, Vaibhav's ambitions leave little room for ambiguity. For all the records he has shattered in the shortest format, he continues to speak of Test cricket with reverence, describing it as his "ultimate dream". The red-ball format, though, can be unforgiving. The swinging conditions, especially overseas, have seen many a talent falter. This is where patience, discipline and technical solidity matter far more than strokeplay. The shift in temperament will be just as important as the shift in format. How quickly Vaibhav adapts will determine whether he remains a thrilling prospect or develops into India's next batting legend. ■

—with Nikhil Naz